永不沉没的神话

The Myth of the Unsinkable



守法的泰坦尼克号，为何仍救不了所有人？

英文原文

On 10 April 1912 the **opulent liner** Titanic left Southampton on her **maiden voyage**. A 1911 **trade journal** had **dubbed** her and her sister ship "**practically unsinkable**". At about 11.40pm on 14 April she **collided with** an **iceberg**; by 2.20am she had **vanished** beneath the waves, and the **death toll** would **surpass** 1,500.

Folklore blames **arrogance**. Yet the Titanic was **compliant with** the law. Under 1894 rules, Britain's **maritime regulator pegged** lifeboat numbers **to gross tonnage** (volume, not weight) on a **scale** that **topped out at** 16 boats for 10,000 tons or more. At about 46,000 tons she carried 20, **exceeding** the **requirement**. Their **capacity** was 1,178, **roughly** half the 2,200 aboard: **sufficient** in law, **inadequate** at sea.

Within radio range, the steamer Californian kept an **equally lawful** routine. Her **sole wireless operator**, Cyril Evans, was **on the payroll of** the Marconi company; when he slept, so did the radio. Around 11.30pm he **switched off** his set. **Hindsight** may call that **negligence**, yet no rule **obliged** him **to** stay **vigilant**, so the Titanic's **frantic distress calls** went **unheard** there.

Between April and July 1912, inquiries in Washington and London heard **testimony** from **survivors** and the Californian's crew. That July, American **legislation** made **round-the-clock** radio watch **compulsory**. In January 1914 **delegates** of 13 nations signed the first Safety of Life at Sea **convention**, **stipulating** lifeboat seats for all, **continuous** radio watch, and an ice **patrol**. The First World War **stalled** the **treaty**; the patrol went ahead **regardless**.

The **doomed** liner sank within three hours. The **outdated** rules she sailed under had **stayed afloat** since 1894; it took her dead to **discredit** them.

中文译文

1912年4月10日，豪华的邮轮泰坦尼克号离开了南安普敦，开始了她的处女航。1911年，一家行业期刊把她和她的姊妹船称为“几乎不会沉没的”。4月14日晚约11时40分，她和一座冰山相撞了；到次日凌晨2时20分，她已消失在海浪之下，遇难人数最终将超过1,500。

坊间流传的说法把灾难归咎于傲慢。然而泰坦尼克号符合法规。按照1894年的规则，英国的海事监管机构把救生艇数量与总吨位（体积，而非重量）挂钩，在一个等级表上/等级体系中，（其数量）最高达（只能）到16艘，针对10,000吨及以上（的船）。她约有46,000吨，带了20艘，超出了要求。它们的容量是1,178人，大约是船上2,200人的一半：按法律足够，到了海上却不足。

在无线电通讯范围内，加州人号轮船遵循的是一套同样合法的值班惯例。她唯一的无线电操作员西里尔·埃文斯，受雇于马可尼公司；他一睡下，电台也一样睡了。晚上11时30分左右，他关掉了自己的设备。事后看来，这或许可称为疏忽，然而没有哪条规则强制他保持警觉，所以泰坦尼克号发狂似的求救呼叫，在那里无人听见。

1912年4月至7月，华盛顿和伦敦的调查听取了幸存者以及加州人号船员的证词。同年7月，美国的一项立法将全天候无线电值守定为强制性的（义务）。1914年1月，13国的代表签署了第一部《海上人命安全公约》，规定救生艇座位要够所有人乘坐，电台要不间断值守，还要开展冰情巡逻。第一次世界大战让这项条约暂缓搁置了；然而冰情巡逻不管怎样依然进行。

这艘在劫难逃的邮轮不到三小时就沉没了。她航行时所遵循的那套过时的规则，却自1894年起一直没有沉没；直到她的乘客葬身大海，它们才信誉扫地。

词汇与表达

opulent adj.
豪华的
the opulent liner Titanic

liner n.
邮轮

maiden voyage adj.
处女航
on her maiden voyage

trade journal 名词短语
行业期刊

dubbed v.
把……称为
had dubbed her and her sister ship

practically adv.
几乎

unsinkable adj.
不会沉没的

collided with v.
和……相撞了
she collided with an iceberg

iceberg n.
冰山

vanished v.
消失

death toll n.
遇难人数
the death toll would surpass 1,500

surpass v.
超过

Folklore n.
坊间流传的说法

arrogance n.
傲慢
Folklore blames arrogance

compliant with adj.
符合
was compliant with the law

maritime adj.
海事

regulator n.
监管机构
Britain's maritime regulator

pegged to v.
把……与……挂钩

gross tonnage adj.
总吨位
gross tonnage (volume, not weight)

scale n.
等级表……等级体系

topped out at 动词短语
最高达……到

exceeding v.
超出了

requirement n.
要求

capacity n.
容量
Their capacity was 1,178

roughly adv.
大约

sufficient adj.
足够
sufficient in law

inadequate adj.
不足
inadequate at sea

equally adv.
同样

词汇与表达（续）

lawful adj.
合法的

sole adj.
唯一的

wireless adj.
无线电

operator n.
操作员

on the payroll of n.
受雇于

switched off 动词短语
关掉了

Hindsight n.
事后看来
Hindsight may call that negligence

negligence n.
疏忽
Hindsight may call that negligence

obliged to v.
强制

vigilant adj.
警觉
no rule obliged him to stay vigilant

frantic adj.
发狂似的

distress calls n.
求救呼叫

unheard adj.
无人听见

testimony n.
证词
heard testimony from survivors

survivors n.
幸存者

legislation n.
立法
American legislation

round-the-clock adj.
全天候

compulsory adj.
强制性的
radio watch compulsory

delegates n.
代表

convention n.
公约
Safety of Life at Sea convention

stipulating v.
规定
stipulating lifeboat seats for all

continuous adj.
不间断

patrol n.
巡逻

stalled v.
暂缓搁置了

treaty n.
条约

regardless adv.
不管怎样

doomed adj.
在劫难逃的

outdated adj.
过时的

stayed afloat adj.
一直没有沉没

discredit v.
信誉扫地
to discredit them

文章简述

- 沉船：1912年，号称几乎不会沉没的泰坦尼克号在首航中撞上冰山，不足三小时沉没，超过1500人遇难。
- 救生：旧法按船体总吨位、也就是容积来定救生艇数，万吨以上只需16艘；泰坦尼克号配了20艘，虽超过法定要求，1178个座位仍只够船上2200人约一半。
- 漏听：附近加州人号的唯一报务员关机睡觉，电台因此没听到求救；他没有违反当时的规定，因为法律未要求全天值守。
- 改革：1912年美国规定无线电必须全天有人值守；1914年13国签约，要求救生艇容纳全员、连续值守并巡查冰情。
- 教训：一战使公约搁置，冰情巡逻仍启动；灾难表明，沿用旧法规，即使配置合法，也未必足以保障安全。